of antibiotics in ICUs and emergency setups is alarmingly high, often driven by diagnostic delays and empirical prescribing. Point-of-care testing is essential and must be integrated into our AMR containment strategies. The government is committed to working with the healthcare industry, private labs, and clinicians to promote diagnostic stewardship and awareness, because the right test at the right time prevents the wrong prescription."'



The roundtable advanced through two structured sessions — **Round One: Understanding the Landscape** and **Round Two: Solutions, Scale, and Strategy** — with active participation from a distinguished panel of experts including **Dr. Arjun Dang** (CEO, Dr Dangs Lab), **Dr. Ankur Mutreja** (Director – Strategy, Communications & Partnerships, PATH), **Dr. Vikas Manchanda** (Professor, Microbiology, Maulana Azad Medical College), **Dr. Aarti Khanna Nagpal,** HOD Biochemistry & Hematology, PathKind Labs, **Dr. Shalabh Malik,** Technical Director Microbiology & Molecular Infectious, Dr Lal Path Labs, **Dr. Chhavi Gupta,** Senior Consultant- Infectious Disease, Adult Immunization, and Travel Medicine, Yashoda Super Speciality Hospital, **Dr. Rajat Gupta,** Director Critical Care & Emergency, Sri Balaji Action Medical Institute, **Dr. Aakashneel Bhattacharya** (Head, Infectious Disease, Paras Hospitals), **Dr. Shweta Sharma** (Senior Consultant, Microbiology, Yashoda Super Speciality Hospital), **Dr. Pooja Wadwa** (Clinical Director, Critical Care Medicine, Marengo Asia Hospitals), **Dr. Ichha Kaur** (Senior Consultant, Anaesthesia, Paras Hospitals), **Dr. Simant Jha** (Director, Critical Care, PSRI Hospital), **Dr. Tariq Ali** (Director, Critical Care, Medanta The Medicity), **Dr. Ashish Bajaj** (Consultant Microbiologist & Infection Control Officer, CK Birla Hospital), and **Dr. Prashant Nag** (Chief Operating & Medical Officer, Redcliffe Labs), among others.

The discussion in Round One centered around identifying the persistent gaps in India's AMR response — from diagnostic turnaround delays and limited lab infrastructure to an over-reliance on empirical treatments in ICUs, OPDs, and emergency settings, where decisions are often made without timely, evidence-based diagnostic confirmation. Experts collectively agreed on the urgent need to empower clinicians with faster, reliable point-of-care diagnostic solutions, improve real-time lab-clinician communication, and implement stewardship protocols. Transitioning into Round Two, the conversation shifted toward scalable solutions — with proposals including hospital antibiogram integration, AMR surveillance networks, syndromic PoC testing programs, public-private diagnostic partnerships, and large-scale clinician stewardship training initiatives. The experts emphasized the importance of bridging diagnostic gaps beyond metros — into tier-2, tier-3 cities, and rural setups — and called for collaborative national awareness campaigns, policy support, and standardized diagnostic-led antimicrobial stewardship frameworks.

The roundtable closed with reflections from **Dr. Lata Kapoor** and **Dr. Ravi Gaur,** summarizing **key takeaways:** prioritizing diagnostic-led decision-making, integrating rapid PoC tools into clinical workflows, generating hospital antibiograms, making AMR data central to hospital policies, and launching national awareness campaigns. The evening concluded with an engaging networking dinner that encouraged open dialogue, cross-sector partnerships, and collaborative planning for future AMR initiatives.

This meaningful roundtable marks a progressive step towards uniting India's clinical, diagnostic, and policy voices under a common mission — placing diagnostics at the center of AMR containment, promoting responsible, evidence-based healthcare, and advancing India's global leadership in combating antimicrobial resistance.

